
1882–1937, POLISH

Szymanowski was born into a Polish landowning family in Ukraine. Showing musical talent from an early age, he first attracted attention as a member of the radical Young Poland group of composers in Warsaw in 1905. His music was initially influenced by German models, notably Richard Strauss, but journeys to Sicily and North Africa stimulated a fascination with Mediterranean culture. During World War I, isolated on his family's estate in Ukraine, Szymanowski produced an impressive series of works reflecting this exotic interest, as well as the influence of contemporary French composers. Caught up by nationalist enthusiasm after Poland's declaration of independence in 1918, he sought inspiration in the folk music of the Tatra Mountains, attempting to create an authentic modern Polish music. He was appointed head of the Warsaw Conservatory in 1927, but his work was better liked outside Poland than within. From 1932, he lived mostly abroad, dying in a sanatorium in Switzerland.

KEY WORKS: Myths (violin and piano), Op. 30, 1915; Violin Concerto No. 1, Op. 35, 1916; Król Roger (opera), Op. 46, 1924; Symphony No. 4 (piano and orchestra), Op. 60, 1932